

groups at www.eyeball.com. Clicking on the Groups button in the interface takes you to the site where groups are listed. You can enter any of these chat groups and start video chatting with people instantaneously. The site tells you a user's status, using different colours in the displayed names. For example, a name displayed in orange would indicate that the person is in a videoconferencing conference with another user, blue indicates that the person is logged onto the Eyeball software and is available for video chat and grey indicates that the person has just come to the site to chat but is not logged on to the software. You can browse the room and if you wish to video chat with a particular user, click on the video button and the software automatically launches from your computer. Once you log in, a request is sent to the user you want to chat with and if the user accepts, a chat window pops up and you can see him/her.

All at once!

Im4cam stands apart from the conventional videoconferencing software. It isn't a one-to-one videoconferencing software; instead, it is more like entering a video chat room. It has an array of 10 windows, which help you see the people in



Colour differences in Eyeball show user status

a particular room. You could either use the common window to send messages or right-click the user name to send a personal message. What's different about this software is that each user can hear all the others. This is an excellent piece of software for personal videoconferences and could prove useful to an organisation which requires its personnel from various parts of the world to collaborate. You can create a personal room, and you could restrict access to a chosen few by applying a password. You can get together with relatives or even your girlfriend abroad, without anyone else butting in!

Let's get pally!

While Paltalk functions similar to Im4cam, it doesn't have a multi window display. This, again, is a chat room setup where you can click on any user and initiate a chat. The best thing about Paltalk is that it has child protection enabled. Hence, if someone types an obscene word in a



Collaborative use of Im4cam

general chat room, it automatically boots him/her from that room. This is a good feature if your children use Paltalk to talk to their friends or relatives. If you subscribe for Paltalk's premium services, you can see the video in the main window, which reduces the hassles of going to private chat to see a person's cam. This software also lets you create locked rooms and you can choose to invite people to join your group. There are other benefits that you could gain if you become a premium services member by paying an amount upfront.

How to pick?

So how do you go about picking the best? Some software boast distinct features but lack in certain aspects. For example, Im4cam lets you have multiple people in a conference but lags in speed of text delivery and is also prone to crashes. While choosing a videoconferencing software, you should base your judgement on your requirements and certain other parameters. For example, if you want ease of control and also the ability to hold multiple one-to-one conferences simultaneously, then Yahoo! serves the purpose quite well. Netmeeting doesn't allow you to have multiple video exchanges simultaneously but it has a unique 'picture in picture' feature that is missing in the others.

Organisation-based videoconferences can be held using the Im4cam multiple window software. Voice and video can be exchanged simultaneously between 10 people at a maximum. But, neither of these software has the facility to report abuse on the usage of Web cams, except for Yahoo!.

Videoconferencing is a huge tidal wave engulfing people all over the world. Choose the software that suits your purpose, get the basic gear in place and start conferencing with your pals and peers, one-to-one or one-to-many. The best part is it doesn't leave much room for paranoia; so the next time you're chatting with foxy-chick_22, you can find out for certain if the person belongs to the female species! 

<http://www.wv>

<http://www.im.co.kr/English/index.htm>

Gives you all the services offered by Im4cam

www.iclips.com

Download software for creating and streaming video

www.eyeball.com

Download the software and check out other offers

www.paltalk.com

Download the Paltalk videoconferencing software for free